MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 2: Dance Like a Man - Mahesh Dattani

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Mahesh Dattani’s Dance Like a Man uses a family’s memories to question gender rules, artistic ambition, parental power, and the stories people tell about failure.

Start with a picture

A child loves an art that a parent calls unsuitable. Years later, the child has become a parent and tells a different version of what happened. The play makes spectators compare those versions instead of accepting the loudest voice.

1. Meet the main figures

Jairaj and Ratna are dancers. Jairaj’s father Amritlal exercises authority within the family. Their daughter Lata is also connected with dance, and Viswas encounters the family through her. The present contains unresolved pressures from earlier generations.

Do not define each figure by a single label. A person can resist one form of control while exercising another.

2. The central conflict

Amritlal associates male respectability with particular forms of work and conduct. Jairaj’s dancing threatens that model. Money, accommodation, family reputation, and the power to approve a career become tools in the conflict.

The question is not whether men are naturally unsuited to dance. The play examines how a social rule tries to make that claim appear natural.

3. Ratna’s ambition

Ratna’s desire for artistic success exists within the same family structure. Her negotiations and choices complicate an easy account of a united young couple against an older tyrant. Ambition may offer agency while also producing dependence or compromise.

A gender analysis should therefore look at relationships and institutions, not simply count which characters are male and female.

4. Memory and time on stage

The play moves between present action and earlier events. Performance can place different ages and roles in a shared theatrical space. An ordinary object, a changed gesture, or a transition in dialogue can make the past press upon the present.

This is not only a convenient way to explain background. Contrasting accounts make memory itself part of the conflict. Ask whose explanation protects a reputation and whose pain it leaves unheard.

5. A later generation

Lata’s opportunities raise the question of whether the family has changed or simply given old pressures new forms. Viswas’s arrival helps expose assumptions that family members might otherwise leave unspoken.

The death of a child and the disputed memories surrounding family choices deepen the emotional stakes. Use the assigned play for exact details before claiming one uncontested motive for every event.

6. Meaning of the title

“Like a man” can sound like an innocent comparison, but it carries a rule about acceptable masculinity. Dance tests the rule by separating an artistic practice from the gender meaning imposed on it.

Quick check

1. Does the play prove dance belongs to one gender? **No; it questions that classification.**
2. Are all memories equally disinterested? **No; they can protect a speaker’s position.**
3. Is the present separate from the past? **No; unresolved experiences shape it.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain the title as a gendered rule.
2. Show how family resources enforce the rule.
3. Discuss Ratna’s ambition and negotiation.
4. Analyse temporal shifts and competing memories.
5. Evaluate the later generation’s relationship to the past.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not reproduce Amritlal’s gender stereotypes as facts or treat one character’s retrospective account as the whole play’s final verdict.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How does the play connect the performance of dance with the performance of gender and family memory?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Dance Like a Man places artistic practice within a household that controls money, respectability, and the available definitions of success. Jairaj's difficulty is therefore not merely personal weakness. His career is judged through a model of masculinity that makes some activities respectable and others suspect. The title exposes the coercion hidden inside an apparently ordinary phrase.

Ratna complicates the opposition between patriarchal authority and artistic freedom. Her ambition gives her reasons to negotiate with the very structure that restricts the couple. The play can consequently examine how agency and complicity coexist. A simple division into innocent artists and a wholly external oppressor would miss this relational complexity.

The movement through time gives the argument theatrical form. Family history is reconstructed through voices that remember, excuse, blame, and revise. The audience is asked to evaluate these accounts rather than receive an objective explanation outside them. The later generation makes the continuing effect of the conflict visible.

A strong answer links a particular transition, confrontation, or role arrangement to this pressure of memory. The play's criticism of gender norms emerges not only from what characters say about dance, but from the way performance reveals the unstable stories through which a family maintains authority.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Examine the contrasting social ideals that drive the conflict between Amritlal and Jairaj in Dance Like a Man.
2. Write a short note on the characterisation of Ratna in Dance Like a Man.
3. How does Mahesh Dattani's Dance Like a Man implicate the politics of gender in the lives of individuals?
4. How does Mahesh Dattani use stagecraft to depict the themes of Dance Like a Man.
5. Briefly explore the dynamics of the relationship between Lata and Viswas.

6. How does the title Dance Like a Man validate and enrich the core themes of the play?